Mark Dery

Escape Velocity: Cyberculture at the End of the Century

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Book Review

—Reviewed by
KENNETH C. RISDON

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The reviewer is head of the Composition Department and a Faculty Technical Consultant, University of Minnesota, Duluth, MN 55812 USA (email: krisdon@d.umn.edu).
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Escape Velocity by Mark Dery provides an unusual look at the power of technology on individuals, culture, and society. Bookstores are full of books on cyberculture that are based on no more than some person's knowledge of and wishful interpretation of current culture and technology. *Escape Velocity* provides much more to the informed, interested reader. Through an informed analysis of hundreds of pieces of art, music, and technology, Dery explains cyberculture's origins, current influences, and possible future. Dery provides a serious critique of the information age and its technopagans, cyberhippies, and technorogues, to examine whether or not technology will enslave or liberate us in the future. The answer, of course, is that it depends on what we do with technology. By implication, Dery makes clear that understanding technology's impact on society and technology itself enables us to guide our destiny.

The title, *Escape Velocity*, presents the central metaphor for this study of cyberculture. Escape velocity is, of course, the speed at which a body "escapes" the pull of Earth's gravity. Dery examines cyberculture's fundamental drive to escape the perils and messy reality of the human body through technology, finally reaching cyber utopia where machines think, reproduce, and evolve. Such a world is both powerfully attractive and terrifyingly possible as we approach the millennium.

Dery examines the social and cultural conflicts of this escape through literature, music, art, sex, and technology. A glimpse of Dery's arguments and a hint of his attempt to avoid producing a dreary, academic tome on culture are provided by his chapter titles: "Turn On, Boot Up, Jack In: Cyberdelia," "Metal Machine Music: Cyberpunk Meets the Black Leather Synth-Rockers," "Waging a Tinkerer's War: Mechanical Spectacle," "Ritual Mechanics: Cybernetic Body Art," "Robocopulation: Sex Times Technology Equals the Future," and "Cyborging the Body Politic: Obsolete Bodies and Posthuman Beings." Unfortunately, readers may have some trouble with Dery's inventiveness unless they are devout members of the cyber subculture themselves and have broad knowledge of not only technology, but also of the subculture art and music of the past 40–50 years. For example, if you have no idea who Timothy Leary and Marshall McLuhan are or what they stood for, you will have to struggle to understand "Cyberdelia," which is drawn from the cyberdelic subculture of the 1960s. However, Dery provides sufficient explanation and numerous quotes to support his points clearly and abundant references for those who want to fully understand the attraction of a culture whose ultimate goal is to "escape" all human frailty with the perfection of technology. Of course, his evidence for this attraction is, in part, simply the number of people who use the Internet today for work or recreation. He also points out that Leary moved from drugs to multimedia. The fact that net users are arguably the dominant cultural group today supports his claims about where techno society desires to go. The

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subculture seems to be rapidly becoming those people without Net access.

In "Metal Machine Music," Dery explains techno music and its origins. Here again, the goal is to replace the human with the machine. True techno rock uses no traditional instruments but rather is produced with synthesizers and mathematical formulas, often based on fractals and Fibonacci sequences. The fundamental problem for cyber-rock is how to produce a representation of today's machine, the computer. Since the inner workings of a computer chip are too complex and too changeable to be represented with conventional musical means, the composers resort to a metaphor drawn from the horrors of the industrial age, the junked machinery of steel mills, etc., and the noise of our society, the sounds of a freeway interchange.

The chapter on "Mechanical Spectacle" further develops the meaning and importance of trying to leave behind the industrial age for the information age. This involves an analysis of the technology of the Gulf War as well as more than a hint at how the technology of Disneyland is connected. Here, Dery shows the links between the counter-culture performance "sculpture" by M. Pauline (robotic monster killing machines) and the "smart" weapons of the Gulf War. Pauline argues that life would be much more interesting if a little money went into developing machines that did "amazing things that people could be part of" (p. 143). All of this helps to explain the attraction of "monster truck" shows where machines destroy one another, an amazingly popular, noisy, nitro-methane-driven spectacle seen across America. Disneyland is simply a cleaned up, sexless version of cruel and violent techno sculpture.

"Ritual Mechanics" presents an explication of the large body of writings on body art and explains such things as the transitions in tattoo art from "MOM" to moving images of machines and computer chips. It also explores the "battle of the sexes" through an examination and comparison of feminist and nonfeminist attitudes toward the body and the history of body decoration. The ultimate goal is to make the body ready for space travel by removing all the organs (putting them on the outside) to make room for technology inserts. All of this helps explain trends in tattoos as well as body piercing. The cyberculture goal of plug-in memory chips clearly is not a long jump from putting gold rings in eyebrows and other body parts.

That sex is important in the information age seems undeniable. On the news, we see endless stories of the dangers to children of sex on the Internet. Certainly, no one who has searched for "breast cancer" on the Web can doubt how prevalent the topic of sex is. "Robocopulation" strives to explain the links between technology and an obsession with sex. Central to the explanation is the origin of the term "cyborg." Dery cites sources that claim that it is a combination of "cybernetic" and "orgasm" (p. 229). Cyberculture literature and art is also dominated by sex. McLuhan recognized this as early as 1951 (p. 183). Dery points out that the expression of interest has spread from e-zines such as *bOING-bOING* to mainstream magazines such as *Elle* and *Wired*. Cyber sex is the ultimate in safe sex. Virtual sex a la *Lawnmower Man* and now many other movies transmits no diseases and poses no risk of offspring. However, the lack of children is clearly a major problem if the utopian goal of self-reproducing machines is realized.

The possibility of a post-human world seems to be just that and not a real threat to humans, at this point, in a literal sense. But in the sense that technology might control human activity, it clearly is a threat as we approach 2000. Dery examines the attempts of humans to control machines, especially "sex machines." In the process, he reveals much about "beauty myths," the significance of morphing (the Terminator, for example) and the conflict between cyborgs and humans.

Escape Velocity is not about the possibility of actually producing a cyborg. No matter. What it does explain is the significance of the art and literature about such possibilities and the very real danger that humans are largely irrelevant within the political systems of a information culture. In "Cyborging the Body Politic," Dery shows that the body is no longer simply a private, spiritual entity, but a political battle ground for issues such as abortion, fetal tissue research, killer viruses, etc. Dery says that at the end of the twentieth century, the materialist view of the human body dominates (p. 231). The struggle between mind and body seems to be over. The body is a machine to be fixed, modified, and used. Thus, morphing becomes the metaphor for the future. In *The Terminator*, the ultimate changing machine is finally dominated by humans. Cyber culture really is asking, but for how long?

For those who really want to understand and finally guide the relationship between culture, society, and technology, *Escape Velocity* is an essential text.